The Littlest Matchmaker

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The Littlest Matchmaker

by ResFlower

Summary

"Mom!" She breathes a sigh of relief she doesn't know she's holding in when she hears their little voice. She finally spots the blonde tuft of hair sticking up haphazardly as Finn looks at her in excitement.

"Finn, baby, you can't just run off like that! I've been calling—" Adora's words stutter to a stop and so does her brain. Finn is holding hands with an absolute bombshell of a woman.

She's striking, one eyebrow slightly raised as she glances down at Finn and then up at her in a this yours? type of gesture. She has black jeans and a crop top on, along with combat boots —she's the last person Adora would think would stop to help a child find their parent at the grocery store.

Finn does a little jump, almost falling over in their excitement. "Mom! Isn't she so pretty?"

OR

Five times Finn inadvertently matchmakes for their mom and one time their mom figures it out another way. Wingbaby AU.

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

One

"Finn!" Adora yells out, looking through the produce section. She knows chances are high that they are in the next aisle over, but she still feels panic clawing at her chest as she looks for them. She doesn't know what she'd do if something happened to them.

"Mom!" She breathes a sigh of relief she doesn't know she's holding in when she hears their little voice. She finally spots the blonde tuft of hair sticking up haphazardly as Finn looks at her in excitement.

"Finn, baby, you can't just run off like that! I've been calling—" Adora's words stutter to a stop and so does her brain. Finn is holding hands with an absolute bombshell of a woman.

She's striking, one eyebrow slightly raised as she glances down at Finn and then up at her in a *this yours?* type of gesture. She has black jeans and a crop top on, along with combat boots —she's the last person Adora would think would stop to help a child find their parent at the grocery store. She also feels a pang of jealousy—she doesn't remember the last time she had the time to dress that good to the grocery store.

Finn does a little jump, almost falling over in their excitement. "Mom! Isn't she so *pretty*?" When Adora's brain starts working again she thinks she's going to die from how quickly the blood rushes to her face. Finn seems completely unaware of their murder attempt, turning back to the stranger. "You're *so* pretty." They inform her seriously.

Her lips twitch in amusement as she takes Finn in. "Thanks, kid." Her eyes fly up to Adora. "This your mom?"

"Yes! Momma doesn't have a lot of friends." They try to whisper but it's loud and this whole scenario is pulled straight out of Adora's nightmares.

"Finn!" She means it to be reprimanding but it comes out almost as a whine.

The stranger laughs now and *oh no*, it's pretty and high-pitched and she probably thinks Adora is such a loser already.

Finn ignores her, still looking at the stranger. "My mom needs more friends. Would you be her friend?"

She reaches out grabbing Finn's free hand. Her child clearly can't be trusted so she's going to have to do what she can to end this painful interaction.

"I'm so sorry. They can be rambunctious. We'll just get going." She tugs Finn up and props them on her hip. Fully prepared to run away with only half her grocery list in her cart.

"Do you need a friend?"

Adora blinks up at the woman, holding Finn to her hip with one hand and pushing a stray piece of hair back with her other hand. "Excuse me?"

The stranger shrugs, shoving her hands in her pockets and smiling. "Your kid seems pretty adamant that you need a friend. So, do you?"

Finn taps her shoulder rapidly. "Mom, say yes!"

She looks at them, her gaze narrowing. This was so much easier when she was just their aunt. "Finn Light Gray." She says slowly, watching as they squirm. "What have we said about interrupting conversations?"

For the first time, Finn looks down and away. "That it's rude."

"That's right." After her parenting moment, she looks up at the stranger again. "I mean, we can always use another friend, I think." It's good to model healthy social behaviors. For Finn. Totally. Not just because Adora hasn't felt this attracted to someone in ages.

The stranger reaches into her pocket, pulling out her phone. She holds it up for Adora to see with a coy smile. "You seem to have your hands full—want to give me your number?"

She tightens her grip on Finn. "Sure." Her voice is too high pitched, but she doesn't focus on it, instead rattling off her number as the woman writes them down. "You can put that under Adora."

"Adora," she says lowly, closing out of her phone. "I'm Catra." She reaches her hand out and Adora almost drops her kid trying to balance them and shakes Catra's hand.

"Cool." She doesn't know what else to say to the gorgeous woman, especially when she smiles like that.

"Well, I'll see you around then." Catra then looks at Finn, giving them a soft smile. "Bye, kid."

Adora walks away before finding her abandoned cart and putting Finn in the seat. They wiggle, already pouting about their restricted range of movement. "You can't walk off like that Finn. It's not safe."

They side-eye her. "But I made pretty friend." She's sure they think that's a compelling argument.

"Catra." She reminds them.

"Cah-tah," they try.

Adora tries not to laugh. It's close enough and realistically, someone as good-looking as Catra is not going to text her. You don't text strangers you meet in the grocery store.

Two

Hey Adora—do you and your kid like burgers?

Thank God Adora doesn’t have read receipts on, because it's been six hours and she still hasn't gotten it together enough to text Catra back.

"I think if a hot girl asks for your number and then texts you about going out, you should say yes." Glimmer sounds almost bored with Adora's panicking. “When was the last time you had a date?”

"We don't know if she's into women. Or that she's asking me out. She asked about me and Finn! Maybe she just feels really bad for the frazzled single mom whose game is so bad her toddler is trying to get her friends." Adora groans and shakes out her hair. “And you *know* I haven’t been on a date since Finn.”

Finn being her responsibility was wholly unexpected and, in some ways, Adora has never recalibrated. She has too much going on with Finn anyway for dating—and there's no way a girl like Catra would be interested. It's doomed to fail from the start. The whole grocery store experience was generally horrifying, and she'd rather forget it.

"Look, I think—is Finn talking to someone on your phone?" Glimmer asks looking over at the toddler.

"They shouldn't be, they were just watching TV on it." She doesn't let them do it frequently, and when she does, it's the educational playlist she's approved. Adora just needs a break sometimes and giving Finn some screen time doesn’t feel like the worst thing she could do.

Glimmer eyes Finn. "That doesn't sound like TV."

Adora walks up to Finn, putting her hand out for the phone. They hand it over and there is a call with an unknown number going on.

She puts the phone to her ear, bending her neck so she can hold it hands-free. "Hello?"

"Hey Adora. I almost hung up. It sounded like you dropped your phone?" Adora is about to drop her phone *now* at the sound of Catra's voice. "I didn't expect you to call me." She lets out a short laugh.

"I'm so sorry." She blurts out, looking at Glimmer with wide eyes, gesturing toward the phone.

What? She mouths in confusion.

Adora points at the phone more frantically. *It's her!* She mimes back.

Glimmer's eyes go wide. *Shit.*

"It's fine. I figured I weirded you out by following through and reaching out. I'm hoping that's not the case?" There's an edge of nervousness in Catra's voice that makes Adora feel bad for not answering sooner.

"Not at all! I've just been busy. You know, toddler." Adora smacks her forehead. She probably shouldn't make her whole personality momzilla. "And other stuff."

"Of course," Catra says agreeably, her voice perking up. "So, might seem a little off, but I was thinking maybe you two would want to hang out. I was thinking burgers, but I'm open." Now that Adora has reassured her, Catra sounds just as smooth and confident as she did in person.

It all throws Adora off. "Why do you want to hang out with us?"

"Uh—beg your pardon?" She hears come from the phone as Glimmer looks like she's turning green just from hearing Adora's side of the conversation.

"I just—not a lot of people want to hang out with a single mom and her kid. It's a lot of baggage."

There's a pause for a moment. "Well, I didn't assume someone like you would be single, but that's good to know." Adora bites her tongue to stop herself from asking about what Catra means by that. "And Finn isn't baggage. They're just a kid. As for hanging out ..." Her words peter out for a moment. "I just moved here to Bright Moon. I don't really know a lot of people and I thought—well, why not take the offer of friendship at face value."

It sounds painfully sincere and sweet, and Adora is so fucked already and she's only seen Catra once. "We love burgers. We also go to the park at least twice a week if that sounds like something you're into."

Finn and Glimmer are both staring at her—Glimmer looks like she's cursing every God because the phone isn't on speaker and Finn stares at her because the word 'park' is a favorite in their vocabulary right now.

"That sounds great. Text me the details?"

Adora nods vigorously even though Catra can't see her. "Count on it."

The moment she hangs up, Glimmer just about explodes. "Tell me *everything*." She demands, all but climbing from one end of the room to the other.

Adora ignores her friend for a moment, looking at Finn. "Baby, did you mean to call Catra?" She can't imagine they did but it feels a little too serendipitous for her to be sure.

Finn looks at her solemnly, head tilting one way. "Cah-tah?"

"Yeah." She nods, running a hand down their back. "Remember, from the store?"

They brighten at the reminder, and they nod. "Pretty friend." They chirp.

Adora lets out a soft laugh. Of course, that's what Finn remembers. "Yeah. Did you mean to call her?"

They shake their head. "No." Their eyes swing to the phone. "Bluey please?"

Adora sighs. It's entirely plausible that Finn accidentally called when pressing buttons on her phone. She's going to need to figure out how to make sure that doesn't happen again. "Alright

bud, I'll put on Bluey."

She quickly pops on the video Finn wants, careful to close out of all of her other apps. She startles a little when she feels Glimmer's hand come down on her arm.

She looks excited as she shakes Adora's arm a little. "Adora! Everything!!"

She shakes her head and laughs. "Okay, okay."

Three

Adora doesn't know how she can connect so much with someone but still knows so little. She's met with Catra twice since the grocery store, both times a quick lunch with Finn. With Finn there, it's hard to get a word edgewise. Still, the little conversation they manage to have around Finn's questions and comments leaves Adora wanting more.

Catra's funny, incredibly smart, and she's sweet underneath her sometimes acerbic humor. If this was before Finn, Adora would have no doubt that she'd pursue her given half a chance. But Adora doesn't know how to navigate showing her interest when she has a whole kid to worry about. Each time they've met, she's positive that Catra is going to give her a polite smile and tell her that she doesn't want to come out to lunch or do anything else with them again. That hasn't happened yet, thankfully.

This time, Adora resolves to have some more time to talk. She suggested they go to the park so that she could get longer stretches of time to speak with Catra. Like she predicted, Finn is interested in playing with Catra for a few minutes, but they can't resist the siren song of the playground. They run off after Adora gives them a reminder to stay where she can see them.

For a little while, she thinks it's a mistake. Catra sits next to her and they both look out at the playground, watching Finn's bouncy curls as they run around but they don't say much. Adora can feel self-doubt creep in—maybe without Finn around as a distraction, she's lost all ability to talk to someone new. To be interesting.

She feels Catra sigh and leans in closer. "So, tell me about yourself." She gives Adora a tentative smile before leaning back on their shared bench. "I feel like I know more about Finn's favorite toys than I do about you."

She shrugs, biting her lip. "Not that much to tell. Single mom and full-time teacher. Lots of kids hanging around." Adora laughs and turns her body so she can look at Catra better.

Her eyes are trained on Adora, and it makes her skin pebble. "What grade?" She asks.

"Second grade. Any bigger and I lose my patience a lot more easily. Especially once they size up the classes." The idea of dealing with twenty-five thirteen-year-olds is what nightmares are made of. "What about you?"

"Started as a finance director in a startup. Need to reign in all the big spending and make sure the projects are actually as profitable as we say they will be."

Adora isn't surprised by that—Catra always seemed accomplished. "Numbers gal, then?"

"Definitely." She grins widely. "Numbers are more straightforward than second graders if I had to guess."

"You can keep the math though. Adding and subtracting is enough for me." Catra looks like she wants to say something, but she pauses, hesitating. Her eyes dart out to Finn up in the jungle gym and then back at her. Adora sighs. "You want to ask about Finn?"

Adora is young and notably alone—it's a question everyone always has once they realize that there is no other parent for Finn.

Catra looks away, chagrined. "I can't lie that I'm curious. You don't seem much older than me —" Her eyes widen. "—not that there's anything wrong with being a young mom."

She puts a hand on Catra's shoulder, silencing her before she keeps floundering. "It's fine. Finn isn't biologically my kid." Adora gives her a soft smile. "My sister and her wife, they were in an accident. No survivors." It was the worst day of Adora's life bar none. Not only had she lost her only sister and the woman who was practically her sister, but she'd gained an impossible responsibility. "I'd been babysitting Finn the night it happened. Mara always wanted me to take them in if anything happened and I said I would." She shakes her head. "Never thought I'd have to keep that promise."

There was nothing else she would have allowed to happen. She'd held Finn tight as they cried when Adora cried. They were too little to understand what happened, but they could sense Adora's distress. She still talks to them about their moms—has pictures and stories of Mara and Hope by the dozen.

Catra takes a sharp breath, shifting next to Adora. "That's...wow. I'm so sorry."

Adora waves her hand. "I've grieved and I will grieve." It'd been a long road, getting a six-month-old baby to take care of when all she wanted to do was lay in bed and cry about how she'll never see her sister again. Then cry more because Finn won't have Mara either. "I love Finn and we have each other. It has to be enough now."

"You're very brave, Adora." Catra hovers close, her thigh gently pressed against Adora's. "Would it be weird if I offered a hug?"

"It wouldn't." Catra immediately wraps her arms around Adora, soft and comforting in a way that feels so much more familiar than a woman she'd met a handful of times. To her embarrassment, tears prick at her eyes. "You give good hugs." She mutters as she turns to hide her tears in Catra's jacket.

She can feel Catra's shoulders shake with a soft chuckle. "Well, as long as you like them." She murmurs onto Adora's shoulder.

"Momma!" Adora looks up at Finn who runs over, not stopping until their body knocks into Adora's knees. They don't seem to mind that they all but crashed into her.

She smiles looking down at them. "What's going on?"

Finn immediately points at the swing, practically bouncing as they point. "Swing!"

Adora sends Catra an apologetic glance. “Come with?”

She grins and nods. “Of course. I can’t miss the swing now, can I?”

When they stand, Catra’s shoulders bump into her and Adora bumps her back. Catra shoots her with what feels like a secretive smile, before making her way ahead, helping Finn onto the swing.

Four

“You always do this!” Catra accuses, swatting Adora’s hand away from her fries. “And then you blame it on poor Finn.”

“I have no idea what you’re talking about,” Adora says with a straight face as she eats the fry that she stole off Catra’s plate. “And don’t think I didn’t see how you took my onion rings.”

“That was last week,” Catra says dismissively, grabbing her tuna melt. “Who can remember that?”

Finn’s little hand shoots out, grabbing one of Catra’s fries and stuffing it in their face. “Thank you, Cat-ah.” They give her a smile that’s mostly mushed potato.

Catra laughs shaking her head. “Just like your mom. At least you’re polite about it. You’re welcome.” Finn goes back to their chicken tenders, apparently satisfied with their loot. Catra looks up at Adora. “How did the talent show go yesterday?”

Adora finishes a bite of her burger. “Good. All the kids had a lot of fun which is really the most we could ask for.” She leans her elbow on the red plastic counter. “What about your presentation?”

“The pitch we got was good. We’ll see when I dig into the reports they sent over after. Those tell the real story.”

“Do you ever feel like a detective?”

Catra tilts her head. “How do you mean?”

“I don’t know, just sometimes you talk about how you interpret all this information to make these decisions and it feels like you’re digging for all the things someone might miss. Like a mystery.” Catra seems to have a need to verify everything that comes across her desk—apparently, both people within the company on outside of it are trying to persuade her by any means possible, even fudging their numbers.

She smiles and shakes her head. “It sounds more glamorous when you put it like that.”

“It seems that way from where I’m sitting.”

“It’s not.” Catra waves her away. If she’s learned anything about the woman in their short and unlikely friendship, it’s that she’s humble when it counts.

They talk throughout lunch, and nothing seems amiss until Catra eyes Finn. “They’ve been quiet.” She notes with some concern.

In the time that they’d been chatting Finn leaned into Adora, rubbing their face into her side. She thought they were just tired, but as she ran her hand over their forehead, it felt warm. Adora frowns trying to tell if that’s just the heat from Finn rubbing their face in her shirt or more.

Almost as if they can sense the attention on them, they start to cry—a piercing sound that tries to shatter Adora’s eardrums along with that of everyone else in the small diner. She tries to take a deep breath and settle her mind enough to figure out how to best handle Finn when she sees Catra get up and grab her bag for her, clearing out space for her to move.

“I’ll grab the check if you want to take them outside or to the bathroom?” Catra offers, Adora’s bag slung over her shoulder.

She nods gratefully, pulling Finn up and taking them outside. Adora starts rocking them, moving her hand over their small back. Sometimes she forgets how little they are because of how big their personality is, but she’s reminded when she holds them close like this. They are inconsolable, yelling loudly and tensing their whole body as they do so. Adora holds in a groan as the desperation starts climbing up her body—she doesn’t know what’s wrong with Finn and that’s her job.

“I got it. What do you want to do?” Catra puts a soft hand on Finn’s back, tone overly understanding as she addresses Adora.

"I'm so sorry, they never do this." She feels the need to apologize—Catra probably doesn’t want or need to deal with a crying kid in her free time. Finn might be breaking out into a light fever, but she can't tell if they're just warm from all the crying they're doing or if they actually feel sick. She gets the sinking feeling that it’s the latter.

"It's fine." Catra rubs her hand up and down their back. "You're good, bud." She reassures lowly.

Adora is struck again by the way that Catra seems to know how to treat Finn like a person but also like the kid they are.

Adora looks down at her watch and groans, panic spiking in her. "We're going to miss our train home." The next train won’t be for another half hour and any other form of transportation that would be faster isn’t in Adora’s budget right now. Normally, she’d just wait for the next train but there’s nothing worse than waiting for a train with a finicky toddler. It looks like that’s what it’s going to have to be though.

She feels a hand reach out for her elbow, and she realizes that in her worry she completely zoned out. Catra looks at her with concerned eyes, hand still rubbing Finn's back softly. "That's alright. I've got a car."

Immediately, Adora shakes her head. "It's out of the way for you, isn't it?"

Catra rolls her eyes. "It's not like you live on the other side of town. I'll drive you both."

Handing Finn off so Adora can get into the car is a struggle and it doesn't happen without quite a few tears. Catra has a nice car and it's so obvious that she's out of Adora's league in every way. Not only is it flashy and new, it's also clean—Adora hasn't been able to achieve cleanliness like that since before she started taking care of Finn.

She feels a gnawing feeling in her gut as she fits Finn into the middle seat, puts on their seat belt, and then slides in beside them. Sometimes when she and Catra talk, she forgets how different their lives are outside of the time that they spend together. The new car smell and expensive leather is a tough wake-up call.

Catra is looking at her through the review mirror before she turns her head, brows furrowed in concern. "You two are ok there? Are they big enough to not have a car seat?"

"They only use a booster now. It'll be alright for a short drive." Adora mentions absentmindedly as she adjusts the seat belt strap around Finn's waist. They kick their feet out, making little grunts that show they're displeased in their seat but thankfully they don't start crying again. Adora wraps her arm around Finn's back, noting how warm it is. It pushes away the inadequate feeling that's blooming in her gut and fills her with concern instead.

"Can you give me directions as we go?" Catra asks as she pulls out of the parking spot.

"Yeah."

The drive is shorter than Adora is expecting—Catra's car is fast and a smooth ride, the wheels low to the ground as they hug the road's curves. The moment it stops, she quickly unbuckles her seatbelt and then Finn's, pulling them into her arms.

They are like a little electric blanket, Adora can feel the unnatural heat coming off them in waves. She shushes them, pulling her bag over her shoulder as she tries to manage both. She feels something tug on her bag and realizes that it's Catra taking it.

She gives Adora a soft smile, placing a gentle hand on her shoulder. "Where do you have your key in this thing? I can get the door."

Adora puts her hand on Finn's head and nods. "It's in the small front pocket." She juts her chin toward the pocket and watches as Catra quickly fishes out her keys and opens the door for her. "Thank you, Catra."

Catra hesitates at the door, her hand on the door frame as Adora walks in. "Can I come in? I want to make sure Finn is alright."

"Yeah, of course."

Adora makes a beeline to her medicine cabinet, quickly pulling out a thermometer. Finn fusses, moving this way and that so quickly that Adora can't press the thermometer to their head.

"Want me to try?" Catra's a few steps away, holding her hand out for the thermometer. Adora hands it over. With her shushing Finn and rocking them a little, Catra manages to take their temperature. "It's one-oh-two."

Adora sighs—it's not too bad of a fever but they're definitely sick. "Could you grab the medicine? It's the red bottle right there."

"Yeah, of course."

Between the two of them, it's easy to get Finn their medicine and then Adora takes them to their room and changes their clothes, putting them in their softest pajamas. By the time she's finished changing them, they have fallen asleep, and she puts them in their bed.

Adora's not sure how much time has passed until she looks up at her phone and sees that it's been a good twenty minutes since she left Catra to change Finn. She wonders if Catra left—it wouldn't be hard to do, she could just close the door. Adora thinks that Catra would come to say bye but maybe she'd be worried about disturbing Finn.

She walks back out and finds that Catra hasn't left at all. She's sitting in Adora's living room, looking around, one hand on the back of the couch. Adora winces as she looks at her living room through Catra's eyes. There are toys all over the ground, half a load of laundry almost spilling out of her laundry basket, and too many blankets on the floor and couch.

"Sorry about the mess."

Catra raises an eyebrow. "I'm not here judging your place, Adora. And if I was, I'd say it looks lived in, not a mess."

She snorts. "That's just a kind way of saying messy."

Catra's eyes squint when she laughs, and she throws her head back. It makes Adora's heart squeeze in her chest. "Come on, Adora, when am I kind?" In Adora's book, the answer is always. She's not sure why Catra expects her to think anything different. Before she can say that though, Catra's face softens, and she takes a step closer. "How is Finn?" she asks in a hushed voice.

"They fell asleep. I figure the rest will be good for them." Adora's gut clenches with guilt. "I don't know how I didn't realize that they were coming down with something. I should have noticed."

"You did notice. You got them medicine and now they're resting." Catra puts a comforting hand on Adora's shoulder. "If you need to take Finn to the doctor or something, let me know and I can drive."

“That’s—you don’t have to do that.” She feels gratitude but also embarrassment—is Catra offering to drive because she can tell that Adora’s struggling?

“I know. But we’re friends. And I want to help if I can.”

Adora nods slowly, wondering how this woman is even real. “Okay. Thank you.”

“No problem.” Catra lets out a soft sigh, glancing toward the front door. “I can go now if you want?”

There’s something about the way Catra drags her eyes to the door and then back to Adora that makes her wonder if that’s what she wants or if she’s being polite.

“I mean, you can stay. I’m probably just going to watch some TV on mute and check on Finn every once and a while.”

Catra eyes her with some trepidation. “You sure? I don’t want to impose.”

“Yeah. You’d be doing me a favor.” Adora bites her lip. “I get really in my head when Finn’s sick. I’ll probably just stare at them the whole time if I’m alone.”

Catra gives her a small smile. “Well, if you’re sure.” She comes around and sits on the couch. “What do you want to watch.”

Catra stays until Finn’s fever breaks.

Five

Glimmer and Bow host a barbeque to commemorate the end of the school year and Finn all but invites Catra to it the moment they see her. Adora hadn’t thought about inviting Catra—mostly because she worries about two important parts of her life clashing in unpredictable ways—but she couldn’t say no, not when Catra looked up at her with a cautious glance, wondering if the invite was for her.

Adora fretted over the whole outing, but she shouldn’t have—Catra looks like she’s been around forever from the way she gets on with Adora’s friends. By the end of the barbeque, Finn has decided that Catra is the absolute best napping spot, spent as they are. Catra looks far from disgruntled, cradling them close even as her eyes flicker to Adora.

“Your kid weighs more than a pile of bricks.” She teases.

“Well, you seem to have adjusted to it.”

She nuzzles her face into the top of their blonde locks. “That’s just because they’re impossibly cute.” Her voice never veers into a coo, but it drips with affection and warmth.

It has truly been an amazing afternoon, even still, basking in the sun near the pool, Adora can’t help but wonder whether this is really how Catra would like to spend her time. “Do you ever … don’t you want to find some friends without kids?”

She shoots Adora a curious glance. “I mean, I do have that. I have some back home and I have a few coworkers I consider friends. Most of them don’t have kids.” Catra slips one of Finn’s curls between her fingers. “Why do you ask?”

“I was just curious.” Adora bites her lip. “Before Finn, I never really hung around kids. And you spend a lot of time with us.”

Catra gives her a long stare, humor clear in her eyes. “Are you fishing, Adora Grey?”

She feels her skin heat, and not from the sun. “No!”

“Do you want me to tell you how much I like you and Finn?” Catra’s lips twitch into a smile. “Because I will.”

She waves her hand. “Forget I said anything.”

Catra leans her elbow into Adora as much as she can without disturbing Finn’s napping position anyway. “You two are my favorite people in Bright Moon.”

Adora’s heart thumps unevenly at the look Catra gives her. “You’re one of our favorite people too.” She can’t help but confess.

For a moment it’s quiet between them until Catra gives her a cheeky grin. “Of course, I am, I make a great mattress.” As if on cue, Finn nuzzles deeper into Catra’s arms. She holds back a laugh looking down at Finn. “I didn’t know little kids could already have so many independent personality traits before we started hanging out.”

“Yeah, they are something else.”

“Do you three need anything?” Glimmer couldn’t be smiling harder if she could, her eyes flying between Catra and Adora before settling down onto Finn. She coos as she looks at them. “They are so cute.”

“We’re good.” Adora tosses a glance at Catra before she gives a small nod of confirmation.

Catra gives Glimmer a charming smile, the kind Adora imagines she usually reserves for board meetings or press releases. “Thanks for having me. It’s a pleasure to meet you.”

Predictably, Glimmer waves her off a look of pure delight on her face. “Trust me, the pleasure is all mine. Adora and Finn won’t shut up about you. It was high time I put a face to the name.”

“Glimmer.” Adora hisses under her breath.

“Does she?” Catra turns to look at Adora, clearly gloating. “Who would have thought?”

Glimmer is happy to add fuel to the flames. “Oh, both of them talk about you all the time.” She assures Catra again. “But especially Adora.”

“I think we’re about ready to leave now.” Adora interrupts.

The host rolls her eyes. “You aren’t leaving until Bow finishes packing leftovers. But I know where I’m not wanted. I’ll leave you two be.”

Catra is smirking at her but she refuses to make eye contact, instead staring out at the pool in front of them. After a moment, the silence is too much to bear. “I don’t talk about you that much.”

Catra snorts. “Uh-huh.”

“Just, you know. The normal amount.”

“How much is that? I’m dying to know.” Her words are so teasing and Adora’s face is on fire now. She can’t possibly admit the truth—when she isn’t spending time with Catra, she’s talking about her. This must be Glimmer’s revenge for being bored half to tears listening to her.

“Whatever amount you talk about me, probably.”

“I somehow doubt that.” Catra shakes her head. “You just said I was one of your favorite people. It’s okay if you talk about me to your friends.” She looks down at Finn’s head on her chest instead of meeting Adora’s eyes. “It’s actually kind of nice.”

Adora blinks for a moment, registering just how *shy* Catra sounds. It’s unlike her. She reaches her hand out and softly brushes Catra’s shoulder. “Well, I do. Glimmer’s just insufferable sometimes.”

Catra looks up a grin tugging at her mouth. “Yeah, I gathered that.” She looks down at Fin for a moment, adjusting them. They wriggle a little, their face scrunched up in protest of the movement until they settle back. “Want to watch a movie at your place if Finn stays down for a nap?” She asks, one eyebrow raised in a blasé way to cover up for the hopeful look in her eyes.

It’s barely even a question. “Of course.”

And One

It took all Adora’s courage to drop Finn off at Glimmer’s house and head over to Catra’s. She’d only been a handful of times—her apartment wasn’t exactly Finn-proof with all of Catra’s expensive and tasteful decor—but she’d never felt as nervous as she did standing before Catra’s door at that moment. Not even the day Finn broke one of Catra’s antique vases.

For a good three minutes, she’s paralyzed, unable to convince her hand to even twitch toward the door handle. Then Adora forced herself to think about what caused her to crack—she’d been looking through some of her older photo albums and found a letter Mara had written Hope. It read like she’d written it early in the relationship. She’d told Hope all about the future she could feel spread in front of them.

At first, the letter put Adora in a tailspin, her heart clenching in her chest because her sister didn't get to have that future the way she'd wanted. She'd give anything for Mara and Hope to be alive and happy again. Adora reread the last line of the note over and over.

Hope, I want forever with you and all the days between. Let's not waste any time.

Her fingers traced over the deep imprint of Mara's writing, the bulky handwriting that no one expected from someone so refined. *Let's not waste any time*.

It made Adora put the letter back where she found it, a knot in her throat as she realized that's exactly what she's been doing in a lot of ways. She can't say she regrets her time with Catra, but that's just it—Adora regrets every day that passes that she doesn't get a chance to see her, to hear her voice, or listen to her thoughts.

She'll always put Finn first, but she's tired of being afraid of being judged. Tired of wanting and then denying herself.

Her hand still wavers as she looks at the solid wood door. Adora doesn't know if Catra wants her, but she'll never know if she doesn't try. Finally, Adora takes a deep breath and knocks.

It takes entirely too long for Catra to make it to the door. At least, that's what it feels like as Adora nervously grips her own pant leg. The door creaks open cautiously, and she sees Catra's eyes widen in surprise as she takes her in.

"Adora?" She wings the door open freely now, revealing Catra in a pair of ratty pajama bottoms and a cutoff shirt. "What are you doing here? Is Finn okay?"

"Finn's fine."

She watches as Catra's shoulders relax and she nods. "Okay." She breathes out before startling. "Shit, sorry. Please come in."

Adora takes the invitation, toeing out of her shoes and placing them on the rack next to the door. Catra's apartment is pretty much spotless. It makes Adora nervous again, remembering how different their lives are.

There's no going back now, though. Catra is staring at her expectantly, arms crossed loosely over her chest as she leans on her door frame. "So, what's going on? Not that you need an invitation to come here, I'm just surprised. You usually call ahead."

"You tell me I don't need to." Her mouth blurts instead of getting to the point.

Catra grins and rolls her eyes. "That's because you don't. If you just came to hang out, I can make us a snack and we can sit on the balcony." Catra perks up at the thought—she'd been inviting Adora to stargaze for ages, but it's usually too late for Finn. "Wait for me here, I have some fancy hot chocolate I can put together on the stovetop in about fifteen minutes it'll blow your mind."

As Catra walks past her Adora reaches out, lightly grabbing her arm and pulling her still. She knows if she lets Catra go now, she'll fall into the comfort of their time spent together and not

tell Catra what she needs. Catra eyes her curiously and a touch concerned. It makes Adora hope she doesn't look as green as she feels.

"Would you go on a date with me?" Adora asks nervously, her hand still soft on Catra's arm.

Catra's eyes narrowed for a moment, her eyebrows scrunching together. "Adora—"

"Wait. I need to say something else." She clears her throat and straightens her shoulders. "Finn and I are a package deal. We can go out without them, of course, but that's my kid. And any partner I have has to be okay with that." She thinks Catra knows but she wants to be sure. She's not sure she could take the heartache, thinking that maybe Catra is okay with them being together but then finding Finn to be too much.

"So—"

"And if you don't want to date, I'd love to stay friends. You mean a lot to me, even though we've only known each other a short time." She takes a deep breath. "I—I just don't want to wonder. I care about you, and I want to know where that could lead."

Catra is silent, staring at Adora with a soft expression. "Can I talk now?"

Adira flushes, realizing in her nervousness she hasn't let Catra get a word in edgewise. "Yeah. Sorry." She nods her head and clamps her lips shut.

"Honestly, I kind of already thought we were dating. Or at least testing out the waters." She gives that shy smile and passive shrug Adora has understood to mean Catra thinks she might be overstepping.

There's no fucking way Adora missed something like this. "What? Really?"

She nods slowly, grinning. "We've been to the movies together. And dinner. The park and walking by the side of the lake." Catra lists off, holding a finger up for each occasion.

"We've taken Finn to all that."

"Finn and their mother are a package deal. Or hadn't you heard?" She teases lightly. Catra looks at her more seriously then. "I'd love to take you out just us too. But I love doing things either Finn just the same."

Adora tries to process the words, the fact that Catra said *yes*. "So ... we were dating?"

That makes Catra snort. "Well, clearly not if you didn't think so."

Adora is undeterred. "But now we are?"

Catra nods, her eyes bright as she leans in. "Yeah. Definitely."

She tightens the loose grip she has on Catra's arm. "Does that mean I can kiss you?" She'd been dying to kiss Catra for months and it's all she can think of now that it seems she's allowed.

Catra nods softly her eyes dipping down to Adora's lips. "You can kiss me whenever you want."

Adora leans forward, her heart pounding in her ears as she finally presses her lips together with Catra's. She feels Catra's hands wrap around her, cupping her chin and running through her hair in a way that lights her on fire.

"Catra." She gasps out. "Couch?"

Catra slows her kisses down Adora's neck. "Are you sure?"

"You want to stick around, right?" As long as this means what Adora hopes it does, there's nothing she wishes to hold back from Catra any longer.

Her eyes are impossibly soft as she nods. "Yes. Of course, I do."

"Then, please." The deep-seated want tugs at her low in her gut. "I haven't—it's been a *while*. And I want this with you."

Catra quickly leads them deeper into her apartment, a large inviting leather couch their destination. Adora all but crawls into Catra's lap, straddling her as she kisses her more deeply. It feels so *good* to touch Catra, to reach out and feel every sliver of skin she's thought about reaching.

Catra's hands slow down, holding Adora tight around her waist. "You want me to stick around too? After?" The edge of her voice makes Adora pull back to look at Catra.

"If it were up to me, you'd never leave again." She confesses.

Catra pulls her into a bear hug, squeezing her tight. She then places soft kisses on her jaw, up her ear lobe, then again on her lips. "I've been wanting you for ages." She pushes her head back against the couch. "But I think we should slow down."

Adora can feel herself pouting before a groan escapes her. "Why? We've apparently been moving at such a glacial pace I didn't realize we were dating. Maybe a little speed wouldn't be so bad?" She thinks back to Mara's words again—now that she knows she can have Catra, it truly feels like a waste not to.

Catra laughs, apparently entertained by Adora's disappointment. She cups Adora's cheek, letting her thumb touch Adora's bottom lip.

"I get it, I promise." Her eyes seem to darken as they trail over Adora's neck and up to her lips again. "But you're more important to me than just a passing thing. And it's not that I need us to be serious or anything before we have sex, but I need the reality to set in a little." She takes a shuddering breath. "I need it to feel real."

Adora touches Catra's face, nodding softly. "We don't have to. I don't want to do anything you don't want to." Her heart aches when she looks at Catra, her body wants to race, but she can slow down if it's what Catra wants.

Catra leans up and kisses her softly. “I do want, though. Too much probably.” Adora makes to stand and Catra pulls her, making it so that she doesn’t move. “Where are you going?”

“Come on.” She stands and pulls Catra with her, pushing her so now they’re lying down on the couch. “This is better.”

They’re lying side by side, quickly finding a way to hold each other. Catra’s head fits perfectly under Adora’s chin and she drops a soft kiss there. It’s not the heated embrace they were engaged in just moments ago, but it’s no less cathartic and intimate.

“What do you mean too much?” Adora can’t help but ask.

Catra lets out a soft sigh, kissing Adora’s neck again before pulling back enough so they are face to face. “I care about you, a lot. I don’t think I’ve ever been this invested in someone before the first date.” A shadow crosses her face. “And I care about Finn. I don’t want to mess this up.”

Adora nods slowly, leaning forward until their foreheads press together for a moment. She feels Catra relax and that’s when she pulls back a little. “I came here tonight because I found a letter my sister gave her wife when they were dating. And it just made me think about how I have all this time that they don’t have but—” Adora shrugs. “I need to spend it in ways that honor that time. And I can’t think of anything that would make my life better than spending more of it with you.”

“That’s—”

“A lot? I know.”

Catra runs a hand over her cheek. “I was going to say really romantic.”

“Oh.” Adora feels her cheeks warm under Catra's touch. “Well, I think if we both try our best not to mess this up, it can’t go too poorly, right?”

She gives Catra a tentative smile, running her hand down Catra’s back.

She smiles widely, leaning forward and kissing Adora softly. “I suppose that’s true.” Catra leans in close again, her face disappearing into Adora’s neck and her curls peeking more prominently into view. “I’m glad you found the letter.”

Adora’s heart pangs at the thought of Mara, but she can’t find it in herself to be truly sad. Not when it feels like for the first time since Mara’s passing, she’s choosing something that’s just for her. “Me too.”

End Notes

I know in theory it is November but it is still October somewhere in the world and I really wanted to get this out before I stopped posting for November. I really enjoyed writing this and I would love to know y'alls thoughts.

Kudos and comments are the best thing ever. I won't be posting again until December but you can find me talking about SPOP on my socials. I'm on Twitter, Bluesky, and Tumblr.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!